

ROSS OLIVER GALGORM CASTLE EDIT

Travel Radio Australia and we're talking about Ireland this month and we're talking with Ross Oliver who's the director of golf at a fabulous place in County Antrim in Northern Ireland. It's called Galgorm Resort. Now Ross, welcome to the program.

Thank you very much Geoff. Ross, tell us a bit about Galgorm Resort. It's a fabulous place.

If people are going to Ireland they can pop in and have a visit. Absolutely, yes. Galgorm is a five-star luxury spa and golf resort located in County Antrim and not far from the North Coast where Royal Portrush of course, host of the 153rd Open Championship this year is located.

It's 35 minutes from Royal Portrush and also 35 minutes from Belfast City Centre, the capital of Northern Ireland. So really well located to base yourself to explore Northern Ireland, be that for golf or for general tourist activities. There's lots going on and Galgorm is the perfect base for that.

Tell us about the castle. You have a very historic castle there. We do indeed.

Galgorm Castle was built in 1618 and it is full of history and culture throughout the history of the island of Ireland. So we're in the middle of a very exciting project with the castle to return it to its former glories and to create a luxury five-star hotel with 30-40 bedrooms, the creation of a cultural hub with the chapel that burned down as part of the Irish Rebellion. So it's a very exciting renovation project at the castle over the next coming years and we hope to see that come to fruition towards the end of this decade.

So exciting times to be at Galgorm. And tell us about your background Ross. How did you get involved with the resort? So I've been there since 2013.

I'm a PGA professional by my current role is that of Director of Golf at Galgorm. So I started my PGA training in 2013 as an assistant PGA professional and since then I've been there ever since. It's been a very dynamic time.

There's been a lot going on. A lot of the developments across the resort including the golf course. We spent a lot of money raising the standard of the golf course getting it to a place where we hosted the Irish Open in 2020 on the DP World Tour.

We've hosted many tournaments including the ISPS Handicap World Limitational for 2021-2023. It was co-sanctioned by the DP World Tour and the LPGA Tour. So yeah, it's been a really busy place and somewhere that I've been delighted to be a part of since 2013.

Tell us about the golf course itself. It must be set in some absolutely beautiful countryside. It is indeed.

It's a wonderful Irish parkland. One of the best parklands on the island of Ireland. It's which meet

behind the 14th tee box and they flow out into Loch Ne from there.

The rivers come into play on various holes. We also have five or six lakes throughout the property which come into play as well as rivers, strong punkening and beautiful Irish mature woodland. So it's a beautiful place to play golf.

It's a very gentle walk which is lovely. There's really only one hill you go up on 16 and you go back down that hill on 17. So for golfers it's a very gentle and enjoyable walk.

You're out in nature getting away from business of lives and enjoying the game of golf. It's a wonderful place to play. Tell us about some of your hidden gems which are close to the resort that people can get out of the resort and see.

What are a couple of your favourites? There's so much to do at the resort and outside as well. Our spa stands alone as one of the top spas in the UK, Ireland and Europe. So once you have enough time in the spa and away from our restaurants and our bars, there's plenty of things to do.

You can go down into Belfast City, explore the Titanic Museum in Belfast, explore Belfast City Hall and everything that Belfast City has to offer. We have two city centre restaurants in Belfast, Cafe Parisienne which overlooks Belfast City Hall and Fratelli Restaurant which is on Great Victoria Street. So there's so much to do in Belfast and around Belfast and obviously in the north coast as well which is 35 minutes in the other direction.

You have the world famous Giants Causeway, Bushmills, Distillery, so much to do around Northern Ireland for a visitor. Speaking of restaurants in the resort itself, you've got a couple of fantastic restaurants. Tell us about those.

We do, yeah. We have a range of restaurants at the resort. Gillies is our grill bar, we have Fratelli Restauranti as an Italian.

The Castle Kitchen and Bar is a beautiful restaurant at the Golf Club which is a sort of smokehouse, steakhouse theme. So there's lots on offer as well as the conservatory which serves lobby lunches and afternoon teas. We have the river room which is a beautiful setting for some private dining experiences as well as breakfast.

And then Elements which is our spa cafe. You can spend all day out in our thermal spa village, enjoy lunch and dinner in Elements Cafe. So there's lots on offer from a food perspective.

The place is very easy to get to from Belfast City isn't it? If they fly into Belfast, how do they get to you or you can pick people up I suppose? Yeah certainly. So the resort is just 20 minutes from Belfast International Airport, it's 30 minutes from Belfast City Airport. So it's a short taxi journey or we can arrange transport with our transport partners who can facilitate groups visiting and touring the whole of Northern Ireland.

It's something we work very closely with our travel partners at Travel Ireland Coaches as well as other travel partners who we use from time to time. And I suppose you've also had some interesting characters visiting the resort, the golfers from all over the world and professionals too who stay with you. Absolutely yeah.

So we were blessed to be to be used as a base for golfers. Golf tourists from all over the world using us as their base when they're here to play Royal Point Rush, Royal County Down, Port Stewart, the famous Lynx courses of Northern Ireland and of course famous golfers have been with us to play to stay with us when they're playing tournaments at Galgorm or when they're up playing in the open championship as well. So we're very fortunate to have them staying at Galgorm and I'm sure they had a phenomenal time with us.

And how can people find out more about Galgorm Castle Golf Club and Resorts online? Very easy. Go to galgorm.com. You'll find out everything that we have they offer at Galgorm Resort and if you want to look at galgormcollection.com it'll show you what else we have they offer outside of the collection. We have two resorts, two hotels and two city centre restaurants all as part of the Galgorm Collection.

Thank you very much and it's Ross Oliver, Director of Golf at the Galgorm Castle. Thank you so much for being with us on the program. Thank you Jeff.

My pleasure.